CHARLES BURGESS
From a portrait painted in Persia

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:09 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from
UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

THE BURGESS PERSIAN LETTERS

Edited by BENJAMIN SCHWARTZ

AMONG the papers, letters, etc.,* presented to the Library by Mrs. Thomas Foljambe Burgess of Scarsdale, New York, are two series of letters from the Near East, written during the years 1827–1855, by the brothers Charles and Edward Burgess, sons of the English banker, economist, and editor, Henry Burgess. These letters afford as connected a history of the adventures and fortunes of Occidentals in the Orient as any "narrative of travel and description" that has been published, while the pen of the trained novelist could make of the story as rich and warm and fascinating a novel as has been written on such a theme. But aside from their interest as human documents and their possible inspiration for the novelist, the letters, written during that period when Turkey became the "sick man of Europe," when Russia was whittling Persia down to her present boundaries, when England was establishing and consolidating her whole position in India and Asia Minor, acquire added value by affording unexpected glimpses into the play and counter-play of the Great Powers, the initiation and prosecution of policies which, at this very moment, are coloring events in Egypt, the western Mediterranean, and the Middle East.

From 1826 to 1828 the closing acts of the drama of Greek independence from Turkey were being played to their stirring conclusion. The famous English diplomat, Stratford Canning, was minister to the Porte; those perennial foes, England, Russia, and France, were banded together in a crusade to free the Christian Greeks; an allied squadron had "blundered" into Navarino bay in 1827 and destroyed the Turkish fleet. In Persia the grandiose schemes of the crown prince, Abbas Mirza, to recover territories lost to Russia was ending in the utter rout of the Persians, the capture of Tabriz by the Russians, and the humiliating Treaty of Turkomanchai, concluded just in time to enable the Czar to declare formal war on Turkey. The British Minister to the Shah, Sir John Macdonald, was striving mightily to throw up any sort of bulwark against a Russian threat to India, and British money, munitions, and drill sergeants for the Persian army (and the concomitant of British manufactured products) were beginning to trickle into the country in ever-increasing volume.

Against this background, Charles Henry Burgess, eldest son of Henry and Frances (Ridsdale) Burgess, went out to Persia at the instance of a Persian merchant, Sadik Bey (later ennobled by the Shah as Syeed Khan) in 1827, at

* See a note, "Gift of Anglo-Persian papers," by Miss Mabel C. Weaks in the *Bulletin*, v. 43, p. 484, June, 1939; without her careful and painstaking arranging and cataloguing of the gift by Mrs. Burgess, this edition of the Persian letters would have been impossible.

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:10 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

the age of eighteen, to join the British military mission under Major Hart, as a Lieutenant of infantry with the forces of H. R. H. Prince Abbas Mirza. Charles does not appear in the British Army List, but his letters, notes, and sketches indicate education and training in military tactics. During his brief career as a soldier he distinguished himself by winning the Persian order of the Rising Sun and Lion, second class, for gallantry in action, and comported himself in such fashion as to win the approbation and confidence not only of his military colleagues, but also of those highly placed in the Persian government.

As a result of connections thus established, in 1829, when Persian finances became so muddled that most of the British military mission had to be released, Charles found himself set up as a merchant, financed by his father, and working through Sadik Bey, and the firm of Hanson, of London and Constantinople. Brilliant and bold in his conceptions, he was successful beyond expectations at the outset, and was probably the first Englishman to ship goods from the mother country through the Black Sea directly to Trebizond in Turkey, thence by relatively easy caravan stages to the markets of Persia, instead of the previous prohibitively expensive route via the port of Bushire in the Persian Gulf. He traveled back and forth between Persia and England constantly during the years 1830–1836, executing private and public commissions, and on at least one occasion, acted as King's Messenger for the British Foreign Office. His restless imagination running riot at the enormous possibilities opened up before him, he kept pyramiding venture on venture until finally, in 1836, the bubble burst. Thereafter, a combination of circumstances such as ill-health, "trouble in the Balkans," inability to satisfy the clamorings of creditors, and perhaps, interest in newer and greener pastures served to prevent his return to Persia. He died at Aix-la-Chapelle during the winter of 1854–1855.

In the meantime, his younger brother Edward, whom he had brought out with him in 1830 and associated in the business, was left in Persia, practically a hostage in the hands of Charles's Persian creditors, who thus vainly hoped to compel the older brother's return. At first Edward's position was extremely precarious, for apart from the risk to his person he led a hand-to-mouth existence which was in sharp contrast to his previous estate as "a prosperous and thriving merchant." But his singularly winning disposition (his widow could still say, twenty-five years after his death, that "he was the most all-loved person" she had ever known) enabled him to retain former friends and make new ones among both Europeans and natives, even those who had suffered from the unhappy outcome of Charles's speculations. Prince Bahman Mirza secured his appointment as civil governor of two small villages, an appointment which, because the villages were in the neighborhood of a community of Nestorian

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:10 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

Christians, led to Edward's acting as financial agent for the American Mission at Tabriz and Urumia. He tutored the Prince's children and had charge of the royal stables. He did odd jobs of translating into Turkish and Persian, both languages of which he had acquired a fluent knowledge. Thus, while continuing to be held officially responsible with his brother, and confined to the general neighborhood of the town of Tabriz, he managed to spend his days not too unpleasantly. His letters abound in the names and events which have brought Asia Minor into the western limelight; many of his references are of prime historical importance not only in regard to the matter discussed, but also the actors involved, with most of whom he had personal acquaintance. Thus, revealing bits of information are afforded us by the retailing of incidents concerning such great names as Rawlinson and Layard, the fathers of Assyriology, or of the inner workings of the British and Russian embassies.

In 1848 Edward's link with the royal house was greatly strengthened by the accession to the throne of Nasir i Din, nephew of the now exiled Bahman Mirza. Edward sold everything he could lay his hands on and joined the triumphal march from Tabriz to Teheran, where he was immediately appointed chief interpreter and later made editor of the state gazette. His most pressing personal concerns were now relieved, for although still technically a debtor, the change in government and the lapse of time had so altered his status that he was practically free to do as he pleased. By this time, however, the East had entered into his soul and the thought of returning to a mercantile existence in England was so repugnant that he cemented his ties in Persia by refusing the offer of a position in America (secured for him by his younger brother George), and finally, in 1852, by his marriage to a beautiful Armenian girl. And so, although most of his career had been shadowed by the meteoric rise and fall of his brother Charles, and although that shadow was only dispelled at the very end of his life, Persia came to mean the *summum bonum* of his existence. One small cloud remained; for a long time he was unable to secure leave to return to England for a visit. Ironically, when he finally did wring *official* permission from the government to leave the country for that visit, he died en route, still in Persia.

THE LETTERS *

[CHARLES BURGESS TO HIS PARENTS] *Smirna, March 10, 1828*

I am afraid you will think I have let slip a very long time without writing but since my last our affairs wore such a gloomy and uncertain aspect that I had no

* NOTE: The letters are arranged chronologically as follows: To and from Charles Burgess; to and from Edward Burgess. Letters relating to either brother, though not part of their correspondence, are inserted in their chronological places.

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:11 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

heart to begin. In fact I scarcely knew which way fate would lead me, and began to entertain serious ideas of turning Turk that I might have no trouble in entering into futurity, but quietly smoking my pipe might leave every earthly care to God His prophet. However I am rejoiced to say that the clouds are now disappearing and I can, with some degree of comfort, sit down to let you into my future movements.

I have before mentioned Sadik Bey's departure from Constantinople. — Mr. Fowler's coming down to Smirna after we had been together some weeks, every body and every thing led us to think that nothing could prevent a war between the three powers and Turkey.[1] The news from Persia was of the worst description. We heard of nothing but the Russians gaining victories, making advances etc. all of which you have of course seen and I need not here enter into. We anticipated nothing but being obliged to leave Smirna and going God only knew whither, our proceeding to Persia appeared for the present impossible. We heard nothing from Sadik Bey who promised to write from Erzeroum, the bad state of the Roads, dreadful weather, the unsettled political events between Russia and Persia, the former of whom was said to be in possession of all the passes, the great danger from Koords and other bandits, and his bad state of health made us have every fear for his safety. Indeed the Pacha of Erzeroum the frontier town of Turkey would not allow travellers to proceed therefore we had the greatest doubt of Sadik Bey's reaching his destination. He desired us to remain quiet for three months in which time he hoped to send us the money and make every arrangement necessary for the journey.

It is now exactly three months since his departure and we have heard nothing from him, therefore have concluded that I should set out alone for Persia which is now practicable as the Russians have agreed to the terms of a peace and to all appearances there is no danger of a war between Turkey and England.[2] I apply here for a Teskeret to proceed to Constantinople from whence I get my firman to go on, every body here appears to think I shall get permission to proceed. We have decided on this step with the concurrence of Mr. Hanson who decidedly considers it the most practical way of acting. In case of Sadik Bey's death, which God forbid, it is necessary to wind up his affairs and no body can do this better than Fowler or myself. Should he be well he will be delighted to hear the present state of affairs and I shall bring information which it is impossible he can procure from any other source, as all communication has been

[1] The Holy Alliance (England, France, and Russia) were threatening to intervene actively in the Greek war of independence.

[2] The Russo-Persian War was brought to an end by the Treaty of Turkomanchai, in February, 1828. This left Russia, who had assumed the role of protector of Christianity, with her hands free for her war with Turkey.

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:11 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

stopped and all he will have learnt can only be from vague reports of the ambassadors having left and which must be calculated to deter him from acting with regard to his property under my charge, the goods are perfectly safe and in good condition. They are shipped in my name on board an English vessel floating in this bay.

It is very important Sadik Bey should know the turn affairs have taken as this must decide his future movement. I shall also be the bearer of very important news such as the change of ministry and there is also a strong report of the king's death.[3] We shall know more however by the next post which we expect daily. I set out 2 or 3 days after its arrival. My own prospects are in any case not bad — the late war must have made the Persians fully aware of the necessity of employing British officers and should all be well with Sadik Bey my interest is as good as it possibly can be. If he is lost to us I have no doubt Major Harte and the English gentlemen will consider favourably of my case. I have seen here a gentleman who has been in Persia and whose accounts are most flattering.

I think it very possible I shall have another journey back again to assist in getting in the goods which will be an affair of considerable difficulty as they can not in any case proceed until we have heard from the Persian government who must apply to the Porte for a remission of duties, leave to pass etc. I have a good deal of difficulty to look forward to in my travels not to mention the unpleasantness of being a month without seeing a Christian face or speaking a European language. I expect to set out from here in four or five days, it is uncertain whether by land or sea, should I find a good Dutch ship going up I will go with her.

You now have a rough sketch of my prospects and probable proceedings, I will proceed to give you some idea of Smirna and the way in which I have spent my time here. The town of Smirna is situated on a most beautiful bay and surrounded by fine bold mountains itself being in the valley and stretching along the sea shore. During the winter these mountains were covered with snow and the cold was severe. The town is badly and irregularly built, there is only one street in it which will allow of a carriage to pass. It is very dirty and altogether disagreeable after European cities but the country is delightful and there are a vast many pleasant villages which are partly inhabited by Turks partly by Greeks and the shooting is capital. We go out for two or three days, take provisions with us and live in one of the Greek houses and seldom fail to bring home a large quantity of woodcocks, partridges and hares.

I was once out on a similar excursion with Fowler and a Lieutenant of the Cambrian. We went to Lidigin a beautiful village distant by four hours from Smirna when there we recollected we were on the road to the far famed Ephesus

[3] Fath Ali Shah, king of Persia. The rumor was false; the Shah did not die until 1834.

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:11 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

(with the sacred history of which you are better acquainted than I am) and all at once we determined to proceed thither. We applied to the Aga for a man as guide and guard which he very kindly gave us and started the next morning two hours before daylight being altogether 5 in company.

After a long and painful days march at first through low marshy ground and after over high and picturesque mountains we arrived at a miserable Turkish village 2 hours distant from Ephesus. There we took up our boots for the night — the only place we could get was a compartment of a stable the roof of which was in such a state that we had the gratification of counting the stars as we lay down and the door half off added to which half a dozen camel drivers were our companions. Poor Fowler was dreadfully deranged by all this. However after getting over the night we set out for the ruins which to my companions completely made up for their suffering during the night, as to myself I was not so much in extatics and in passing a fine Basso Relievo over an archway I fired a ball to bring down a piece of the knee to carry away. I knocked off a piece but the Antiquarians were so dreadfully outraged that I was obliged to give them the precious piece of marble as a peace offering.

At Ephesus we could find nothing to eat either for ourselves or our horses, but they told us that if we went to Lelan Miova 4 hours distant over the mountains we should get everything we wanted. Thither we went and found the Turks in the greatest ferment at our approach, the Consulate was closed and the Consul had been gone ever since the news of the battle of Navarin[4] and there was not a Frank in the place. With much trouble we persuaded a Jew Dragueman to let us into the empty Consulate and sent a man to the Aga to say we were Americans who wished to stay there that night. He answered we might remain in the Consulate that night but he advised us to depart by daylight in the morning, and to take a different route as he could not answer for the intentions of his people with regard to us. We thanked him and started in the morning at 4 o'clock and after a ride over the mountains of about 16 hours arrived at Lidigin, where we stopped the night and proceeded the next day to Smirna and were told by the people there we might think ourselves very lucky to have come off so well during a time when we had neither Ambassador nor a Consul in the Turkish dominions.

I had written this much intending to have sent my letter from Smirna but having decided to sail on the 12th on board a Dutch ship I determined to send it from Constantinople. I will merely now inform you that I arrived here [Constantinople] safe on March 25th after a delightful passage, that I have found here a Dr. Schultz, a professor in the employ of the French government who has

[4] The more or less accidental encounter between an Allied squadron and the Turkish fleet in the harbor of Navarino accomplished the total destruction of the latter, and dealt Turkish naval forces a blow from which the "Sick Man" never recovered.

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:12 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

agreed to be my travelling companion and we shall set off as soon as possible probably by the Black Sea to Trebizonde and thence to Tabriz by land. My companion is a fine young professieur I like him much.

I have been kindly received by both the Dutch and Austrian ambassadors and by all the English merchants here but there is but little society, most of the people having left for the present. We appear perfectly secure here I have been over all Constantinople and the surrounding country in company with an Austrian officer and Engineer. I must leave description for my next letter which I shall send by the next post which leaves about the same time as we expect to do.

I sent by the Skylark Captn. Davis bound from Smirna to London a small present for all of you which I hope you will accept rather as coming from Turkey than for the value of the things contained. There are 4 pairs slippers with the outer shoes to fit as near as I can guess my Father, Edward, Joe and George, 6 common Turkish purses and one of a better kind and 1 Doz of Oil of Roses in different bottles some in the shape of an opera glass others pipes boots etc. If I can find any thing worth sending here I will procure it.

Since writing the above we have had the insurpassable pleasure to receive a kind letter from Sadik mentioning his arrival and that if possible he will send a Tartar to us with every thing necessary for our proceeding with the goods. This however cannot be at present as it is impossible the goods should come up here without the presence of a British Ambassador therefore we are of opinion that my journey should be prosecuted. Sadik's letter is full of good hopes and kind sentiments. God grant they may be fullfilled.

In Sadik's letter he mentioned that his friends there would be glad to receive me and to place me in such a situation of course military as I was fitted for.

[Syeed Khan to Henry Burgess.] *Constantinople, June 10, 1828*

I had only time to offer you a hasty postscript to Mr. Willsonnes Letter by the last post, but fearing it might not be sufficiently explanatory respecting your son Charles I beg to repeat that part of it which relates to his military appointment in the Persian army which is as follows. — He will receive 18,000 piastres per ann. as Lieutenant, House in Garrison and Tents in Camp, Forage for three Horses all the Year round, Baggage to be carried and a Set of Carpets. He will also get 9000 piastres for the Expenses of his Journey out, but he must at least agree to serve the Prince[5] for five years — after which time if he chooses to go home, he will get another 9000 piastres to take him home, to make all this sure I had procured a Firmin for him, which I have enclosed in a Letter to him to await his arrival at Tabreez. I shall be very happy if this proves satisfactory both

[5] Abbas Mirza, oldest son of Fath Ali Shah.

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:12 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

to him and yourself, and I have no doubt he will acquit himself to the entire satisfaction of the Prince as well as to Major Hart under whose immediate care he will be placed. I find that he left Smyrna on the 11th March in the Dutch Brig the "King of the Netherlands" that after a passage of Six days he arrived here and remained until the 1st of May, being four days before my arrival, when he went by Vessel up the Black Sea to Redoutculu on his way to Georgia from thence his way is very clear to Tabreez. Such is the Outline of his History to that time of which he has no doubt given you full Particulars, which I hope reached you in due course. Mr. Willsonne will have communicated to you the particulars of my Journey to and from Tabreez, which saves me the Recapitulating — and since I wrote to him I have not quite fixed on my Plan for returning but tis most probable to be by the Black Sea. As yet we know nothing certain here of the movements of the Russians nor if they have crossed the Danube and this uncertainty renders it so difficult to decide on what Route to take. I am the more anxious to return to Tabreez to make arrangements for another Journey to England when I hope to have the pleasure of seeing you in London.

SYEED KHAN, late SADIK BEY

[CHARLES BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS.] *Tiflis, July 3, 1828*

You will be surprized at the date of this letter as my last was from Constantinople since that I did not give you any certain intelligence that I should proceed through Russia — however here I am and upon the whole feel glad that I have taken this course although much that has occurred since my departure from Constantinople have changed my vision and expectations in what way I cannot here explain to you as this letter is almost sure to bee opened before it reaches your hands. On May 1st I set sail from Constantinople having with some difficulty succeeded in finding a ship going to Taganrog — after a prosperous voyage of 16 days including 6 quarantine I landed at the lazarretto in Taganrog where I had still 14 days to remain in confinement on shore. When I left Constantinople it was with the intention of landing at Kertch in the Crimea from thence embarking for Redout-kalè and thence proceeding to Tiflis which is only 5 days journey, on arriving at Kertch I found there was little chance of my getting an opportunity to proceed by sea to Redoutkalè and the governor told me I should run great risk of being made prisoner or killed by the Mahometan tribes who inhabit the country between the Black Sea and Tiflis and as the war was already commenced against the Turks they would be sure to plunder and carry off any Christian they might meet — he therefore advised my proceeding to Taganrog and from there going by land to Tiflis, this I did and after a journey of 20 days arrived here.

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:12 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

I must not dwell too long on the occurrences of the route but leave them for another opportunity at Tabreez from whence I shall have plenty of time for writing fully. On my journey from Taganrog to Tiflis I met with Major Willock the brother of Sir Henry of whom you have already heard during the short time we were together — this gentleman shewed me every possible kindness and certainly the information I received from him does not diminish my hopes of doing well. Every body I have seen here praises in the highest degree the conduct of the English throughout the war — the Russian officers who have been at Tabreez all speak with the utmost gratitude of the reception they have met with from the English indeed from all sides I have heard the same opinion respecting my countrymen there — this you may suppose is no small satisfaction to me.

The round I have been obliged to make by way of Taganrok has cost me much more than if I had prosecuted my intended route by way of Nimgraha and here I am under the necessity of purchasing horses to take me to Tabreez as the posts which were disarranged by the war have not yet been reestablished. I am obliged to purchase three horses and this together with the increased expense of the journey has obliged me to draw on you hard.

I am much pressed for time as I leave at twelve oclock to night it is now eight. The weather is so hot it is impossible to travel in the day. I have for companion as far as Erivan a young Russian officer nephew of the famous Yermoloff[6] an exceedingly pleasant young man — he is going to join the army under Pa[skevitch][7] which is now directed upon Erzeroum. My next letter shall contain a complete budget of all my adventures since writing, the voyage and journey have been extremely interesting particularly the passage of the Caucasus which is certainly worth coming from London to see.

My bill is for 45/6/3.

[Charles Burgess to his Parents.] *Tabreez, July 25, 1828*

I only arrived here yesterday so that I cannot enter into particulars. I am at Major Hart's who is certainly one of the finest samples of a true English officer I ever beheld. If he was my Father he could not be kinder to me than he is. Every body here has received me well. Colonel Macdonald, Sir Keith Jackson and all the officers have called and offered their kindest attentions to me. Sadik Bey left here for Constantinople in April and as it appears has contrived to pass his goods through Constantinople and is now on his way to Persia — he writes

[6] General Alexei Petrovich Yermoloff, 1772–1861. He had distinguished himself in the Battle of Borodino, in 1812, against Napoleon, and was in command of the famous Caucasian corps in 1817.

[7] Field Marshal Ivan Fiodorovich Paskevich (Paskiewicz), Count of Erivan, Prince of Warsaw, 1782–1856.

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:12 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

me in the kindest way and appears perfectly satisfied with my conduct. The Prince Abbas Mirza received him very well has granted him all his requests and the mines the commerce to England and the silk trade will be in his hands entirely — he is also made a Khan. I expect you will see him in England again very shortly.

Should it be particularly inconvenient to you to pay my Tiflis bill do not think of it — by the time it is returned it will be perfectly in my power although the effect will be bad of having it returned. I should think some of my relations would do me the favour to pay and I will most positively promise to send the money to England by the first convenient opportunity . . . I would have sent the money by Mr. Mackenzie the gentleman who is kind enough to take charge of this but it is impossible I can receive it until I have been presented to the Prince who will not return from Teheran for twenty days. But do not by this suppose that I am not authorized to call myself a Lieutenant in his services this I am perfectly I have his own signature to the agreement in Persian.

I have now a commission to beg of you to perform on the part of Major Hart his little son Alexander who is with his brother is not yet placed at school the Major has not the highest confidence in his brothers (who is a great disciplinarian) judgment in this matter. Now he wishes you to inform me of the best schools you know of — the Major wishes him to be placed where he can have the best possible education and more liberty than boys generally have at schools, for example he would like him to have a horse or pony to be allowed to ride out and above all to be perfectly instructed in this art which in Persia is of the first importance. Religion is of no importance that is to say of the sect of the master. I proposed Dr. Morrell should he still keep school or if not where my brother Joe was at Liverpool. He appeared to like the idea of Dr. Morrell extremely and I hope you will inquire if he has retired altogether or not.

You may suppose the march from Tiflis to Tabreez in the middle of July was not the pleasantest ride in the world — my nose and cheeks were completely raw with the sun before I got here but as to health I never felt stronger or better in my life. The gentlemen here lead most temperate active lives that is to say Major Hart Dr. Cormick and Major Willock. You must send your letter for the present until Turkish affairs are arranged by way of St. Petersburgh you will not find any difficulty in getting some of the Petersburgh merchants to take charge of them there and they must be there enclosed and forwarded under cover to Mr. Le Chevalier de Gamba Consul de France à Tiflis who has kindly promised to take charge of any letters for me.

Should you see Capt. Hart do not mention anything about the school the Major is willing to pay for school expenses only from 100 to 140£ pr. ann.

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:13 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

[CHARLES BURGESS TO HIS PARENTS.] *Camp two days march from Tabreez*
September 13, 1829

Just 20 months ago I wrote you a letter in which I mentioned all my affairs as settled and myself as established in the Princes service, this turned out very differently. When the Prince returned from a journey to Teheran his affairs were in a very bad state the debt to the Russians[8] in a great measure unpaid and the regular army could not that year be collected. Under these circumstances he decided upon not accepting us and broke his agreements and every thing else, notwithstanding the repeated remonstrances of Major Hart, the Ambassador etc. At this time there came to Tabreez a Coordish Pacha whose country lies midway between Tabreez and Bagdad, he wishing to introduce discipline into his army applied for us and we entered into an agreement with him, that is to say a Mr. Christian nephew of Dr. Cormick and myself and started with him for his country *Sulimanieh,* during this time I particularly avoided writing to you as the country I was placed in is considered dangerous for Franks even to pass through and I did not wish you to be under unnecessary alarms, and hoped and believed I should soon return to the Princes service which has eventually turned out to be the case. We served Mahmoud Pacha for a period of nine months much to his satisfaction and were treated by him like his own sons, at the end of this time while the Pacha and ourselves were out engaged in a war with the Rewandoos a neighbouring people his brother Governor of the country during his absence became a traitor and with the assistance of an army from Bagdad succeeded in turning him out of his country, and we all came together to the Prince Abbas Mirza encamped here. I was particularly well received, was told he had heard an excellent character of me, and desired my services, to which I of course assented and am now if no new misfortune takes place in his service but he has cheated us in pay which he has docked down in pay from 500 to 400 tomauns pleading the distressed state of finances and promising after a year to increase us. If this lasts I am satisfied. We are now in a camp with 7000 disciplined troops artillery etc. gaining much useful information and satisfied that in this country with great industry and application there is every probability of ultimately doing something. I now speak the language fluently, have travelled much, been in many dangers and difficulties from which I have happily escaped with an unimpaired constitution and although severely wounded some time back now completely recovered. From Coordistan we thought ourselves happy to get off with our necks whole and our little stock of money, leaving all our other baggage to the conquerors. I of course have many long stories to tell of adventures but now have not a moment to spare. I will now write constantly pray let

[8] The war indemnity imposed by the victorious Russians.

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:13 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

me hear from you as often as possible. I cannot express my anxiety to know how the family is situated. Sadik Bey now Seyd Khan is on his way to England after deceiving me and subsequently treating me very badly do not believe one word he says either about Persia or anything else. Mr. Fowler who is with him will tell you the truth, every body here is disgusted with Sadik and I expect his character is already public in England but you need not take any conspicuous part in making him known unless asked, I have reasons which I will explain hereafter. I am afraid you will not be able to read this I am writing sitting crossed legged and in a tremendous storm of wind and rain which blows my paper in all directions. Col. Monteith who takes charge of this goes through Russia and I must finish as he leaves immediately.

(To be continued)

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:13 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN